

Why clause structure is judged like tense and agreement: public-update operators and grammaticality

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Abstract

Why do speakers treat some readily understood forms as errors of grammar, while treating others as matters of wording, accent, or style? I argue that one major class of grammatical contrasts tells interlocutors how to treat an utterance: as a question rather than an assertion, as committing one participant rather than another, or as linking a participant or referent across clauses. I call this their PUBLIC-UPDATE ROLE. A contrast belongs to the operator stratum when it has such a role and forms a small, conventional paradigm. The definition applies to the paradigm, not to every token. A gender marker can be redundant in one clause but informative elsewhere; **goed* can select the intended past value but use an excluded exponent. Opportunity density then affects how concentrated and resistant to change the licensing pattern becomes, not whether the contrast is an operator. The account also separates operator errors from other grammatical failures. English excludes **depend of* through a community-specific complement construction even though no public-update value has been mis-set. This distinction yields three discriminating tests: tonal, prosodic, and gestural operators should pattern with segmental ones; value errors and value-intact exponent errors should invite different kinds of repair; and locally redundant tokens should prompt update-oriented repair only where their paradigm has an independently measurable public-update role.

Keywords: grammaticality, operator stratum, public update, licensing, preemption, clausal architecture

AI USE. The large language models Claude Opus 4.5 and Claude Fable; Ox Alpha; ChatGPT 5.2 Pro; and GPT-5.5 served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

I THE PUZZLE: WHY “GRAMMAR” PICKS OUT SOME THINGS RATHER THAN OTHERS

The asterisk is selective. Some mismatches are treated as straightforward errors of “grammar”: wrong agreement, illicit clausal morphosyntax, incompatible tense–aspect morphology, missing obligatory evidentials, or mis-selected question particles in systems where such particles are required. Other mismatches are treated as infelicities of social positioning: an accent that indexes the wrong stance,

a style that fails to fit the activity type, or a form that sounds “too formal” or “too intimate”. Still others are treated as matters of lexical choice: poor perhaps, but not illicit.¹

A familiar temptation is to reduce this to a contrast between “structure” and “use”: morpho-syntax counts as grammar; accent and lexical choice don’t. But this gloss is neither typologically adequate nor explanatory. Many languages use prosody or tone as obligatory exponents of grammatical contrasts (Hyman, 2011; Ladd, 2008). Many grammatical categories aren’t universal: a language may lack tense (Comrie, 1985) or number (Corbett, 2000) while sustaining categorical judgments elsewhere. And some lexical items enter operator contrasts, with constraints indistinguishable from inflectional morphology (Bybee, 2010; Hopper & Traugott, 2003).

The core question concerns why some form–value relations become non-negotiable parts of a community’s repertoire while others remain negotiable resources for stance, identity, and content selection.

The argument developed here is that one important part of this difference tracks a difference in VALUE: what a contrast does in a system and what it rules in or out for uptake.² Consider polarity: choosing *not* over an affirmative changes what inferences are licensed. A question particle rather than a declarative ending changes what kind of move the utterance counts as. Such contrasts tell interlocutors how to treat the utterance. I call that contribution a PUBLIC-UPDATE ROLE, and a closed paradigm with that role an OPERATOR paradigm.

The claim is deliberately narrower than an account of every asterisk. A community can exclude a construction such as **depend of* without any operator value being wrong. Conversely, an operator value can be right while its exponent is wrong: **goed* expresses past time through an excluded form, and a concord error can be locally redundant while violating an established paradigm. Constructional licensing, operator value, and exponent choice remain separate. The sections that follow define that distinction, show how clause structure can realize operator paradigms, and derive empirical comparisons with accent, lexical choice, and constructional convention.

2 WHY SOME CONTRASTS ARE PUBLICLY ACCOUNTABLE

A deliberately non-idealized view of grammar starts from a community’s repertoire of conventionalized form–value relations, not only its strings or derivations. Those relations enable coordination in interaction.

Consider two misfires. In the first, a speaker uses a same-subject marker where a different-subject marker is required, or selects a declarative complement where an interrogative one is intended. The hearer responds “Wait, who did what?” or “Did you mean that or whether?” Repair targets the grammatical contrast because it affects how the contribution is to be understood. In the second, a speaker uses an accent or register that doesn’t fit the setting; the hearer understands the utterance but reacts to the speaker’s social positioning: “Why are you talking like that?” What’s targeted is stance or persona, not the move itself.

This contrast reflects what I’ll call PUBLIC ACCOUNTABILITY. Interlocutors don’t merely exchange signals; they make commitments mutually recognizable and ratifiable (Clark, 1996; Clark &

¹ Speakers do label accent and dialect variation as “bad grammar” for social reasons, but the interactional repair profile differs, a point taken up in §9.

² Here VALUE has the Saussurean sense of *valeur* (de Saussure, 1916): the identity of a linguistic unit is constituted by its position in a system of contrasts (what it patterns with, what it opposes, what interpretations it makes available). It isn’t to be confused with feature-value assignment or decision-theoretic value.

Brennan, 1991; Stalnaker, 1978, 2002). Some grammatical contrasts tell them how to treat an utterance: as a question rather than an assertion, as committing one participant rather than another, or as linking a participant or referent across clauses. I call this contribution a PUBLIC-UPDATE ROLE. It's public because the resulting move is available for acknowledgement, challenge, answer, or repair.

Repair practices make this selectivity visible. When an utterance isn't understood, or is understood under a suspect analysis, interlocutors systematically mobilize repair (Schegloff et al., 1977). Repair is evidence about which dimension mattered in the interaction; it isn't part of the definition of that dimension.

Public accountability isn't the same as public consequence. Accent and style are central to social meaning, but they aren't normally grammatical instructions for what an utterance counts as in the way that clause type, polarity, or evidential marking can be (Agha, 2007; Coupland, 2007; Eckert, 2008, 2012). Lexical choice is similarly accountable in an ethical or epistemic sense: one can be challenged for using a slur or a misleading term. Those reactions differ from repair of the grammatical value that organizes the update.

The contrasts that combine public-update work with a closed conventional paradigm constitute what I'll call the OPERATOR STRATUM.

3 THE OPERATOR STRATUM

3.1 THE OPERATOR-STRATUM HYPOTHESIS

An operator paradigm is a small, conventional menu of grammatical values that helps determine how an utterance enters public interaction. I use OPERATOR narrowly: not for everything called an operator in grammatical theory, and not for every construction that speakers judge categorically. Membership has two conditions.

(1) PARADIGM-LEVEL PUBLIC UPDATE. Taken across its ordinary occasions of use, the paradigm conventionally helps determine what move is made, whose commitment is at issue, how participants or referents are linked, or what responses are relevant (Farkas & Bruce, 2010; Murray, 2014; Stalnaker, 2002). Clause type, illocutionary force, evidential anchoring, and switch-reference are central cases. The condition applies to the paradigm, not to the information carried by every token. An agreement marker can be redundant in one clause and decisive in another while the agreement paradigm remains a resource for participant or reference tracking.

Membership is a fact about a community's repertoire; experiments and corpora provide evidence about it. Comprehension probes can ask whether changing the value changes who did what, with what force, or under whose commitment. Next-turn distributions offer a coarser diagnostic when comparable tokens vary naturally. Questions should alter rates of answers and counter-questions, for example. Such distributions need to distinguish uptake responses from sanction, stance, and assessment. Neither diagnostic defines the world-side category it estimates. The companion model represents the relevant target as an expected difference in public update (Reynolds, 2026a).

The condition concerns licensed update types rather than whether a claim is true or successful. A speaker can say *It's true* of a false situation: the assertion fails epistemically, but affirmative polarity and declarative force are licensed. By contrast, *Yesterday the bill passed* selects a past-time anchor; **Yesterday the bill pass* misselects its realization in varieties where finite past morphology is obligatory.

Contextual anchoring is constrained. Context selects among independently licensed operator values, constructional frames, and ellipsis patterns; it doesn't create a form-value relation ad hoc. *I have*

five years can succeed as an elliptical reply to “How long do you have left?” because the frame supplies the relevant duration. The same reply to “How old are you?” fails in ordinary English because age is expressed through the *be* frame, not because the hearer lacks the intended meaning.

(II) PARADIGMATIC CLOSURE. The values belong to a small, conventionalized contrast set. They recur in describable structural environments, their alternatives are mutually exclusive there, and the set isn’t freely expanded token by token. Tense paradigms, agreement systems, switch-reference systems, and complementizer inventories are central cases. Idioms and fixed collocations may be rigid, but their words don’t thereby form a grammatical value paradigm.

Opportunity density modulates the resulting licensing profile. It affects how much evidence speakers encounter and how strongly competitors preempt one another, which can make the profile more categorical, stable, and resistant to exposure. A moribund case contrast can remain an operator while its judgments grow less concentrated. A frequent collocation can be sharply conventional without becoming an operator.

The two conditions are synchronic criteria. A separate diachronic hypothesis holds that public-update work favours recruitment into closed grammatical paradigms. That proposal needs historical evidence and can’t rescue a contrast that fails the synchronic test. Once a paradigm is established, dense competitor evidence can stabilize its licensing pattern; population persistence also requires adoption and retention dynamics, not Bayesian learning alone (Reynolds, 2026a).

This separation yields two useful dissociations. First, a token can carry little information while belonging to a paradigm that contributes to public update across its occasions of use, as with many gender and agreement markers. Second, an update-relevant resource can remain outside the operator stratum because it doesn’t form a closed paradigm, as with many interjections and discourse markers.

Operator contrasts can be morphological, syntactic, phonological, prosodic, gestural, or lexical in form. What matters is their conventional contribution, not their expressive substance. Morphology and clausal architecture are privileged only where they instantiate operator contrasts.

The term OPERATOR is continuous with, but not identical to, its use in Role and Reference Grammar, Functional Grammar, and Functional Discourse Grammar. That tradition treats aspect, tense, modality, negation, and illocutionary force as operators over layers of clause structure (Bentley et al., 2023; Hengeveld, 1989; Hengeveld & Mackenzie, 2008; Van Valin, 2005; Van Valin & LaPolla, 1997). This comparative concept adds the two criteria above: a public-update contribution and a closed paradigm.

Operators are contrastive at a different level from phonemes. Phonemic contrasts primarily keep expressions apart. Operator contrasts help determine how an expression is to be understood as a public move. Both can form paradigms, but only the latter satisfies the public-update condition.

Operators can be compared, cautiously, to protocol headers: they help determine how material in their scope is to be interpreted. The analogy captures broad scope but doesn’t supply a processing mechanism. More importantly, expression shape, constructional licensing, operator value, and exponent choice aren’t exclusive bins. A single error can occupy several of these dimensions at once.

The second row, together with paradigmatic closure, defines the operator stratum. The other rows explain why an operator value can be correct while its exponent isn’t, and why a non-operator construction can still be categorically unlicensed. The central puzzle narrows to why clausal architecture so often packages values for clause type, commitment, role allocation, and reference tracking, whereas accent and much lexical choice don’t.

Question	Bearer	Possible token failure	Example
Constructional licensing	Community repertoire	The intended construction is excluded	<i>*depend of</i>
Operator membership	Closed value paradigm	The paradigm configures or fails to configure public update	clause type
Value selection	Token in an operator paradigm	The wrong grammatical value is selected	same vs. different subject
Exponent licensing	Form realizing a selected value	The intended value is right but its form is excluded	<i>*goed</i>

Table 1: Four questions that the surface asterisk can conflate. They’re dimensions, not exclusive error classes.

3.2 BOUNDARY CASES

Public consequence isn’t enough for operator-stratum membership, and categorical correction isn’t enough either. Table 2 separates the two membership conditions from the route by which a token can fail.

Case	Closed?	Public-update role?	Failure route	Expected response
Wrong tense/evidential value	yes	yes	value selection	update clarification
Question-particle omission	yes	yes	saturation or exponent choice	context-dependent
<i>*goed</i>	yes	inherited from tense	exponent choice	form correction
<i>*le biver</i>	yes	inherited from definite reference	allomorph choice	form correction
<i>*depend of</i>	narrowly licensed construction	no	constructional licensing	form correction
Slur/taboo item	no	public act, not grammatical update	social action	sanction of act or speaker
Interjection token	often no	sometimes	open repertoire or stance	uptake negotiation
Phonotactic mismatch	not a value paradigm	no	expression shape	recognizability repair

Table 2: Operator membership and token failure route. A form correction doesn’t by itself diagnose an operator.

The cases make two boundaries especially clear.

Slurs satisfy the public-consequence test but usually fail the operator test. A racial slur used as a vocative, or a misogynistic slur used as a predicate, can radically alter the social action performed and can make the speaker answerable for that action. But the utterance normally remains structurally fileable as an address, assertion, accusation, or description. The move is morally or socially impermissible even though the hearer can identify its update type. The predicted response is sanction of the act or speaker, not repair of an operator value.

Interjections sit closer to the operator stratum. They can configure uptake, stance, attention, repair, or floor management (Ameka, 1992). In the English cases discussed by Reynolds (2026d), *oh* can mark a change in epistemic state, *huh?* can initiate repair, *mmhm* can acknowledge or continue a turn, *uh* can delay while holding the floor, and *wow* can display surprise or assessment.

But many interjection tokens aren’t selected from a closed set of mutually exclusive values in the way tense, polarity, or clause type are. They can be repeated, stretched, blended, newly coined, or substituted without producing a categorical licensing failure. In those cases, an odd interjection may disturb uptake or stance without leaving the utterance outside the operator repertoire. If an interjection-like form is conventionalized into a closed, distributionally accountable paradigm, it can enter the operator stratum; uptake configuration alone isn’t enough.

French **le hiver* is an operator-exponent case. The definite determinative contributes reference setting; its singular forms are realized as *le*, *la*, or elided *l'* under morphophonological and lexically conditioned restrictions. French H MUET words such as *hiver* pattern with vowel-initial words and trigger elision, whereas H ASPIRÉ words block it (Boersma, 2007). The intended value in **le hiver* is still definite reference. What fails is the licensed realization of that value: the required form is *l'hiver*. The pattern is analogous to a Turkish plural or past suffix whose grammatical value is recoverable but whose harmonic allomorph is excluded (Reynolds, 2026a). Lexical conditioning narrows which exponent the construction licenses; the determinative remains part of a paradigm.

The same operator-exponent analysis applies to **goed*: past time is the intended operator value, while *went* is the established exponent. **Depend of* belongs elsewhere. Complementation is organized by community conventions that are partly schematic and partly head-specific. A head can select a complement category or function while narrowing its realization to a PP headed by one or a few prepositions; English *depend* licenses *on* or *upon*. **Depend of* is a constructional-licensing failure in a dense niche, even though the dependency and intended meaning are recoverable. No public-update value has been mis-set. Its categorical correction shows why the operator stratum can't be equated with grammaticality as a whole.

The boundary generates a direct test. If allomorphy in a paradigm with no public-update role produces the same comprehension and repair profile as wrong operator values, public-update role hasn't marked the proposed boundary. Historical recruitment can't be added after the fact to absorb such a case.

3.3 IDENTIFYING OPERATOR PARADIGMS

The two membership conditions require independent evidence. Judgments and correction practices are consequences to be predicted, not shortcuts to membership.

PARADIGMATIC CLOSURE. Corpus and descriptive evidence should identify a small, enumerable value set recurring in specified structural environments: polarity contrasts, evidential sets, tense-aspect systems, agreement paradigms, switch-reference markers, question particles, or complementizer inventories. Closure isn't inferred from the asterisk.

PUBLIC-UPDATE CONTRIBUTION. Comprehension probes should test whether changing a value alters clause type, commitment, role assignment, reference tracking, scope, or the relevant response space while conceptual content is held constant as far as possible. Broad scope is common because many such contrasts organize the clause or a multi-clause sequence, but scope alone doesn't establish membership.

OPPORTUNITY COUNT AND PREEMPTION. Opportunity is measured as the number of occasions on which a candidate and its competitors could plausibly have been selected. High counts concentrate evidence for operator exponents such as *went*, but they also concentrate evidence for non-operator constructions such as *depend on*. Opportunity predicts the strength of a licensing boundary, not operator membership. A population-level exclusion also depends on how speakers adopt and retain variants; updating alone doesn't produce it (Reynolds, 2026a).

Left-branch extraction illustrates the resulting division of labour. English speakers repeatedly ask about modifier-noun packages, and *Which car did you buy?* occupies the interrogative niche in which **Which did you buy car?* might otherwise appear (Reynolds, 2026e). Whether the latter is a preempted gap rather than a structurally starved option requires independent niche norming; it can't be read from absence alone (Reynolds, 2026a). If that norming succeeds, repeated attributable

competitor wins explain the concentrated evidence against the variant. Whether the construction belongs to the operator stratum is a separate question about its role in interrogative packaging.

The identification order is thus fixed before outcomes are inspected: establish the value set and its environments, test its paradigm-level update contribution, and count its opportunities. Categorical judgments, repair profiles, and processing measures can then test what that independently identified contrast predicts. Because the diagnostics track contribution rather than substance, tonal, prosodic, gestural, and segmental exponents are assessed on the same terms.

4 WHY CLAUSAL ARCHITECTURE BELONGS TO THE OPERATOR STRATUM

Treating clausal architecture as a matter of arranging words gives an English-biased picture. Across languages, operator exponents include affix order in polysynthetic systems, templatic morphology, clitic clusters, tone melodies, nonmanual marking, rigid word order, flexible order coupled with case, and mixtures of these resources. The relevant generalization concerns operator packaging rather than linearization.

The thesis is narrower than “all syntax belongs to the operator stratum”. Clausal architecture belongs with tense and agreement when it realizes publicly accountable operator contrasts: clause type, argument linking, dependency scope, and reference tracking. Some syntactic constraints may instead reflect expression-shape regularities, processing limits, or constructional conventionalization. The syntax most readily experienced as grammatical mismatch is predicted to be operator-rich, but not every syntactic asterisk is an operator mismatch.

The relevant claim concerns projectibility: what observing some features licenses us to predict about others (Goodman, 1955). Once a closed paradigm with a public-update role has been identified, observing its value and opportunity profile should license further expectations about correction, response type, and resistance to exposure within a stated community and activity range (Reynolds, 2026b). Projectibility is an analyst-side relation between observed and expected features. It doesn’t cause a speaker’s feeling; concentrated exposure and task-sensitive read-out explain that response.

Clausal architecture packages operator contrasts in at least four domains.

CLAUSE TYPE AND RESPONSE SPACE. Interrogatives, imperatives, declaratives, and related types encode different update potentials and different norms for what counts as a relevant next move. The contrast is interactionally basic, and languages grammaticalize interrogatives using heterogeneous resources (particles, morphology, intonation, or combinations) (Dryer, 2013; Ladd, 2008). Where a language requires an interrogative exponent for the intended question, declarative morphology leaves the addressee to decide whether to answer or merely acknowledge; the intended public update is unsettled.

ARGUMENT LINKING AND PARTICIPANT ROLES. Clausal organization encodes which participant is presented as actor, undergoer, experiencer, and so on. The implementation varies typologically, but closed case, agreement, or voice paradigms can constrain the recoverable role assignments in a publicly accountable way. If the wrong role is signalled, the hearer may track the wrong participant as agent or patient, derailing downstream inference.

DEPENDENCY MANAGEMENT AND SCOPE. Some complement contrasts package how information is nested, attributed, and scoped. *Kim knows that Pat left* presents an embedded proposition, whereas *Kim wonders whether Pat left* opens an embedded question. **Kim wonders that Pat left* misselects the complement type for the intended update. Here constructional licensing and oper-

ator value intersect: the matrix head restricts the complement construction, and the complementizer helps identify whether the embedded contribution is propositional or interrogative (Farkas & Bruce, 2010; Stalnaker, 2002).

REFERENCE TRACKING ACROSS CLAUSES. Many languages treat cross-clausal coherence as an operator contrast. Switch-reference is a textbook case: a morphosyntactic system signals whether the subject of one clause is the same as or different from that of another (van Gijn, 2016). A wrong marker licenses the wrong tracking relation or leaves tracking unresolved, which can derail the whole multi-clause sequence. The key point here isn't the particular pivot (which varies) but the fact that a community can grammaticalize the tracking problem as operator value.

To illustrate the form of the claim, consider Amele, a Papuan language in which dependent switch-reference verbs in clause chains mark whether the relevant argument is maintained or changed across adjacent clauses (Roberts, 1987, 1988, 2023). Roberts's examples contrast forms such as *h-um-ig* "come-SS.SEQ-1SG.NOM" and *ho-co-min* "come-DS.SEQ-1SG.NOM" before a final tense-marked verb. The operator contrast isn't "a content word"; it supplies a clause-linking operator value. Operator mismatches are predicted to be treated as structural mismatches: the wrong marker licenses the wrong clause-linking update, or leaves the intended update unresolved.

A second, different kind of illustration comes from Japanese sentence-final particles. In many registers, *ka* conventionally marks interrogative force, while declaratives are unmarked or carry other particles; intonation interacts with these choices, and colloquial speech allows more variation (Kuno, 1973; Shibatani, 1990). The particle helps determine what kind of move the utterance counts as and what responses are licensed. Membership in a clause-typing paradigm doesn't make every omission an error. An omitted *ka* may yield a declarative construal, an intonation-marked question, or another licensed move. It becomes relevant to ungrammaticality only where the construction makes an interrogative value obligatory, excludes a competing value, or blocks a combination with other particles, intonation, or morphosyntax. Obligatoriness is a separate, historically conditioned property of the construction rather than an automatic consequence of operator membership (Reynolds, 2026a).

Together, the Amele and Japanese cases separate two claims that are easily conflated. Some clausal operators generate clear structural mismatches when the wrong value is selected; others, like *ka*, show operator membership without automatic failure. In both cases, clausal architecture matters because it packages values for public update, not because syntax is insulated from interaction.

Complementation also shows why community convention and operator value remain separate. Complement constructions are schematic: they assign categories and grammatical functions, while particular heads may narrow a complement to a clause of a certain type or to a PP headed by one of a small set of prepositions. English *put* conventionally requires a locative complement, and *depend* selects *on* or *upon*. These are constructional-licensing facts even when no public-update contrast is involved. Complementation intersects the operator stratum where its values also configure commitment, clause type, scope, or participant linking, as in *that* vs. *whether*. Schematic inheritance and lexically narrowed realization coexist.

5 WHY TENSE AND NUMBER BEHAVE SIMILARLY WITHOUT BEING UNIVERSAL

Tense and number enter grammaticality judgments through the operator paradigms that particular languages grammaticalize. In a language without obligatory tense marking, the mere absence of tense morphology supplies no operator-value error. Other constructional requirements can still make a

clause unlicensed. This account avoids a common slippage between salience in familiar European languages and cross-linguistic necessity (Haspelmath, 2007).

Tense marking is an especially clear example. Where tense is grammaticalized, it can form an operator contrast for temporal anchoring, and wrong values are often treated as licensing failures (Comrie, 1985). Where tense isn't grammaticalized, temporal anchoring is managed through aspect, evidential access, discourse particles, and contextual inference. Speakers in the latter case shouldn't experience missing tense marking as an operator error, because their repertoire contains no obligatory tense contrast to leave unsatisfied.

Number behaves analogously. In languages where number is obligatory in agreement or nominal morphology, it's part of the operator repertoire for tracking reference in public commitments, and a number mismatch is a paradigmatic licensing failure. In languages where number is optional or limited, other contrasts fill the reference-tracking role, and number mismatches have different status (Corbett, 2000).

Operator repertoires vary across languages; where grammaticality judgments track licensing failures, they target operator contrasts *wherever those contrasts occur*.

6 GENDER AND NOUN-CLASS CONCORD AS A HARD CASE

Gender and noun-class concord are the limiting case for the account. With many inanimate nouns, a gender mismatch has little or no effect on the interpretation of that token: **le table* normally doesn't leave the hearer wondering which object is meant. But it's treated as a central grammar error where gender concord is obligatory (Corbett, 1991).

That pattern would be hard to explain if public-update value were a token-by-token membership condition. The relevant question is instead whether the concord paradigm contributes to participant or reference tracking across its occasions of use. Where it does, a locally redundant marker can inherit the role of the paradigm, just as an identifiable past-tense exponent remains part of the tense system. High opportunity density then concentrates evidence for the licensed concord forms, so a wrong exponent can be corrected even when the local referent is obvious.

Public-update role remains empirically constrained. The Mahowald-style point is local redundancy: agreement can be redundant in most clauses while remaining decisive in the minority where lexical semantics, animacy, or discourse expectations underdetermine reference (Mahowald et al., 2023). Whether a particular gender system has that paradigm-level role is an empirical question for comprehension probes, not a fact licensed by the existence of categorical judgments. A diachronic claim that reference tracking favours the recruitment of concord systems remains a separate hypothesis.

The operational prediction has two levels. A gender manipulation on an inanimate noun may have no measurable effect on that token's interpretation, while probes spanning the paradigm still reveal a positive contribution to reference tracking. The theory is challenged by a closed, dense paradigm whose contribution remains near zero across those probes but whose wrong values produce the same comprehension and repair profile as independently identified operators. Categorical correction alone isn't enough to falsify the boundary, because constructional licensing can also be categorical.

7 WHY ACCENT AND LEXICAL CHOICE ARE USUALLY DIFFERENT

Accent and lexical choice typically have different kinds of value.

7.1 INDEXICAL VALUE AND NEGOTIABILITY

Accent, style, and register contribute indexical value: they position speakers relative to social categories, stances, and activity types (Agha, 2007; Coupland, 2007; Eckert, 2008; Silverstein, 1976). Indexical value is often rich and structured, but it isn't typically implemented as a small closed paradigm tied to public update. Interlocutors can reinterpret an accent shift as play, accommodation, quotation, or stance work. The contrast remains socially accountable without thereby becoming an operator contrast.

Indexicality can be obligatory in social practice without becoming an operator licensing condition. Much indexical meaning is *meta-pragmatic*: it becomes salient through social ideologies and enregisterment processes (Agha, 2007; Eckert, 2012). That makes it both powerful and variable, but it rarely supplies an operator value that has to be selected for the utterance to count as a recognized move.

7.2 CONCEPTUAL VALUE AND OPEN CLASSES

Open-class lexical items primarily contribute conceptual content, and their inventories tolerate expansion and innovation. Lexical choice can be infelicitous, misleading, or socially harmful without mis-setting a grammatical update. Lexically conditioned patterns can still be categorical: a head can impose constructional restrictions on its complements, as *depend* does, while the open lexical inventory remains outside the operator stratum.

"Open-endedness" has two dimensions that matter here. Lexical inventories are open in the sense of expandable type-sets. Compositional semantics is open-ended in a different sense: unbounded productivity from combining a finite stock. Operators lack the first kind of openness, but they participate fully in the second: negation scopes, evidentials anchor commitments, and clause type constrains response space. Closed inventories make it easier for repeated choices to concentrate licensing expectations, but closure alone doesn't supply an operator role.

That difference predicts why a wrong operator value and a poor lexical choice can invite different responses even when both are understood. The former can alter the public classification of the move; the latter usually invites negotiation about content. Constructionally excluded lexical combinations remain a third possibility.

7.3 CROSS-SUBSTANCE OPERATORS

Operator status is a role, not a substance. Phonological material can be an operator exponent, and lexical items can enter operator contrasts when they grammaticalize.

Systems in which tone marks tense, focus, or polarity are paradigmatic cases of phonological material realizing operator value, and they should attract operator-directed repair where the relevant value is obligatory or mutually exclusive (Hyman, 2011). Intonational contours that conventionalize clause type are operator exponents; when they're required or exclusionary, they should pattern like question particles rather than like accent (Ladd, 2008). This aligns with work on rising declaratives and intonational commitments, where intonational tunes modify context-update functions rather than merely colouring pronunciation (Gunlogson, 2003; Rudin, 2022).

Signed languages make the same point in another modality. In American Sign Language, a yes/no question can be marked by nonmanual cues such as brow raise over the relevant clause. The operator value is carried by scopal nonmanual marking, not by a segmental word, but it still configures clause type and response space (Sandler & Lillo-Martin, 2006).

Lexical items can enter operator contrasts through grammaticalization. Paradigms shrink, content fades, and licensing constraints emerge (Bybee, 2010; Hopper & Traugott, 2003). Function words, particles, auxiliaries, complementizers, and polarity items can realize operator values. Lexical form alone is insufficient. A preposition selected by a particular head may realize a community-specific complement construction without configuring public update. Its lexical source, constructional licensing, and operator role are separate questions.

Phonotactics sharpens the same point. Phonotactic constraints are conventionalized and often treated categorically (“not a possible word”), but they don’t satisfy the public-update condition. They regulate expression shape rather than the grammatical value of the move. The likely repair target differs: recognizability for phonotactics, update value for operators, conventional form for constructional or exponent licensing, and content or stance for many lexical and pragmatic mismatches. These are tendencies to test, not exclusive response bins.

7.4 A SCOPE ANALOGY

Operators often affect how other material is interpreted. Once an utterance is marked interrogative, the remaining material is understood as the content of a question rather than an assertion. Polarity changes the inferential contribution of material in its scope; case and agreement can constrain role assignment. Operators don’t always reduce more uncertainty than lexical items: predicates such as *congratulate* and *accuse* can reshape continuations dramatically.

The protocol-header comparison is useful only as a scope analogy. Operator values can organize the interpretation of material in their domain: assertion vs. question, self-commitment vs. attributed commitment, or one role assignment vs. another. A wrong value can prompt reanalysis beyond the exponent itself. But linguistic operators needn’t precede their scope, and value-intact exponent errors needn’t produce global reanalysis. The analogy doesn’t provide a processing mechanism or an information-theoretic derivation.

This explains a puzzle: grammatical marking is often locally redundant.³ Mahowald et al. (2023) show that across 30 languages, subjecthood in simple transitive clauses can usually be inferred from lexical content alone. Overt grammatical cues are redundant in a majority of everyday cases, but decisive for the minority where lexical semantics doesn’t settle the roles (reversible events, non-prototypical assignments). Operators can be locally redundant but globally update-relevant. Their contribution isn’t to maximize information in each occurrence, but to supply a codebook whose values remain available when context, lexical semantics, or discourse expectations underdetermine the update.

Frequent, predictable grammatical material often undergoes phonetic reduction. Reduced exponents can still belong to a closed paradigm because operator membership depends on the paradigm’s contribution, not on phonetic invariance.

Opportunity structure supplies a separate prediction. Repeated, attributable competitor choices can concentrate evidence for a licensing boundary (Bybee, 2006, 2010; Reynolds, 2026a). Wrong operator values may prompt broader reanalysis of material in their scope; value-intact exponent errors instead predict form correction with the intended update preserved. This split, not the header metaphor itself, is the processing claim.

³Engineers call this redundancy; linguists call it agreement.

8 TYPOLOGICAL CONSEQUENCES: WHICH CONTRASTS QUALIFY AS OPERATORS

The operator stratum is a comparative concept: it identifies an interactional role that can be realized by different structures in different languages (Haspelmath, 2007). Typological diversity then concerns which contrasts meet the two conditions, not whether English categories are universal.

Four domains are particularly instructive.

8.1 INSTRUCTIVE DOMAINS OF VARIATION

EVIDENTIALITY AND EPISTEMIC AUTHORITY. If evidentiality forms a closed paradigm in a language, its values should configure whose commitment is at issue and on what evidential basis (Aikhenvald, 2004). Where a construction also makes one value obligatory, wrong values should invite repair of that commitment structure. Where evidential meanings remain lexical or periphrastic, comparable claims can be challenged as deceptive or inappropriate without establishing an operator paradigm.

EGOPHORICITY AND PERSPECTIVE MANAGEMENT. If a language grammaticalizes perspective or ego-involvement as a closed paradigm, then perspective mismatches should pattern like agreement mismatches where the paradigm makes one value obligatory or excludes another: repair targets the operator value. Tibetan languages and others have been argued to do exactly this (Floyd et al., 2018; Tournadre, 2008). Regardless of the preferred analysis, these contrasts are prime candidates for operator-stratum membership: they govern whose epistemic position is encoded as the relevant anchor for a clause's update potential.

Where perspective doesn't form a closed update-configuring paradigm, similar meanings remain expressible but are more likely to be negotiated as pragmatic alignment than repaired as an operator value.

PHONOLOGICAL EXPONENTS VS. ACCENT. If tone marks tense, aspect, or polarity in a language, then tonal mismatches should pattern like morphosyntactic mismatches when the intended operator value is fixed by the construction or context, not like accent shifts. That prediction makes tonal languages a crucial test case (Hyman, 2011). A language may distinguish tense values primarily through tonal melodies on the verb (one pattern for remote past, another for recent past), with minimal segmental differentiation between the forms.

A concrete case is Ngwi, a West-Coastal Bantu language whose Tense–Aspect–Mood–Polarity system includes grammatical tone in a compact set of verbal conjugations (Pacchiarotti & Bostoen, 2024). In such systems, tone can realize an operator value rather than merely index accent. A wrong tonal value may invite “did you mean X or Y?”; a wrong realization of the intended value may instead invite form correction. Sociophonetic tonal variation can index region or age without changing either. The diagnostic belongs at the paradigm level: does the tonal contrast encode TAMP values that configure the update, or an indexical field that identifies the speaker?

SWITCH-REFERENCE AS INSTRUCTION. Switch-reference systems exemplify how clausal architecture can package an operator contrast beyond simple word order. In Amele, for example, a dependent verb in a clause chain can mark same-subject vs. different-subject linkage before the final tense-marked verb (Roberts, 1987, 1988, 2023).

- (1) a. *Verb-SS.SEQ ... Verb* (instruction: keep same participant active)
- b. *Verb-DS.SEQ ... Verb* (instruction: switch participant role)

This marker choice is an explicit instruction for reference tracking: it constrains the assignment of participant roles in the upcoming increment. An operator mismatch (using the same-subject marker

when the subjects are different) disrupts reference assignment and clause linkage; repair targets reference tracking, not stance or style.

8.2 THE BOUNDARY CASE: T/V AND GRAMMATICALIZED SOCIAL DEIXIS

If an indexical distinction such as addressee status becomes obligatory and paradigmatically closed, some mismatches should pattern less like free register choice and more like operator-value errors. T/V distinctions test this prediction (Brown & Gilman, 1960; Helmbrecht, 2013). French *tu* and *vous*, for instance, can be negotiated in some relationships but tightly constrained in institutional ones. The resulting overlap is expected: a wrong form may be socially sanctionable as address behaviour and structurally repairable as the wrong paradigm value. The contrast qualifies as an operator only where the closed paradigm itself configures participant roles in the public update.

9 GRAMMATICALITY JUDGMENTS AS A SOCIAL TECHNOLOGY

Grammaticality judgments can function as a social technology: they let speakers and institutions mark forms as belonging to, or falling outside, a repertoire. When such judgments concern operators, three variables organize the practice.

The OPERATOR REPERTOIRE records which contrasts exist and what values they conventionally take in the community. The ACTIVATION PROFILE records which contrasts are in play in a register, activity type, or genre: a formal written register may activate a subjunctive contrast that's dormant in casual speech. The ACCOUNTABILITY PROFILE records how participant roles calibrate correction: L2 learners, children, and visitors to an unfamiliar dialect region may be evaluated differently even when the same local repertoire is active.

Situation/ascription/identification conditioning gives these profiles their social architecture. The immediate situation selects the activity, medium, footing, and task; speaker ascription supplies durable baselines such as region, generation, institutional role, or learner status; and identification tracks the norm-centre participants orient to as relevant. These dimensions condition both which repertoires are available and how departures are treated. A form can be licensed for participants oriented to one norm-centre and unlicensed for participants oriented to another, without either side being confused about its form or meaning (Reynolds, 2026c). Negative concord illustrates the point: *I didn't see nobody* is licensed in some English repertoires and excluded by standardized-school norms, even when the intended negative meaning is readily recoverable.

These profiles help explain why grammatical conventions can be stable without making every correction communicatively necessary. Signaling-game models show that coordination problems can produce categorical local conventions and arbitrary exclusions (O'Connor, 2019). They don't establish that actual communities converge by that route. Speakers also often remain understandable when they depart from grammar (Pullum, 2019). The relevant accountability is practice-constitutive: participating in a linguistic practice can make speakers answerable to its constraints (Millar, 2004), but it doesn't entail moral obligation or a corrective-control mechanism.

Repair fits the same pattern. It treats some departures as requiring correction and others as negotiable (Schegloff et al., 1977). A wrong operator value can prompt clarification of the move; a value-intact exponent error can prompt correction of the form; and a constructional error can be corrected even without an operator contrast.

This framing also clarifies why categoricity is common but not inevitable. Some operator contrasts are supported by dense opportunities and tightly constrained constructions, which makes judg-

ments sharp. Others have smaller opportunity counts or are contested across norm centres, which makes judgments more variable. The same dynamics can make non-operator constructions categorical, so categoricity is a projection of concentrated licensing evidence rather than a diagnostic of operator value.

Speakers frequently label accent or dialect choices as “bad grammar” to enforce social hierarchies. Overt correction is rare, but its target can still distinguish practices. “Did you mean the past form?” targets an operator value; “you mean *went*” targets its exponent; “you mean *depend on*” targets a complement construction. Ideological correction instead targets the speaker’s social index while the utterance remains understood (Agha, 2007; Eckert, 2012). These response types can overlap, so they must be coded rather than assumed.

Slurs and taboo words remain boundary cases for the same reason. They’re publicly accountable in a strong sense, but the typical sanction targets an impermissible action rather than a defective update instruction. The same surface reaction, “you can’t say that”, can block a social move or reject a linguistic instrument.

The analysis addresses one target of grammaticality talk, not how such talk is socially deployed. The operator stratum provides material for language ideology, but that doesn’t make judgments politically neutral. Who speaks for “the community”, who can correct, and with what consequences are questions about the social life of the practice.

The target of operator-directed grammaticality talk isn’t identical to the output of a judgment task. Operator membership and licensing are population-level properties of a conditioned repertoire. Corpus counts and comprehension probes estimate those properties; felt ungrammaticality and correction are speaker-level read-outs shaped by exposure, processing, social penalty, task design, and metalinguistic training. Evidence, estimate, and read-out shouldn’t be substituted for the world-side target (Reynolds, 2026a; Reynolds & Miller, 2026).

10 PREDICTIONS AND RESEARCH STRATEGIES

The strongest tests compare contrasts after closure, opportunity, and competitor strength have been measured independently. Otherwise a closure-and-frequency account predicts most of the same outcomes.

(1) REPAIR TARGETS SHOULD FOLLOW THE ERROR LOCUS. Overt repair is rare overall, but wrong operator values should disproportionately invite clarification of force, commitment, role, or reference. Value-intact exponent errors should invite correction of the form with the intended update preserved. Constructional errors such as **depend of* can produce the same surface format, “you mean X”, without an operator-value repair. Indexical mismatches should more often invite stance negotiation, accommodation, or person-targeted sanction (Schegloff et al., 1977).

Operationally, corpora should code value, exponent, constructional, and indexical mismatches separately, with the target independently recoverable and participant access controlled. Adult interaction in communities without formal schooling is especially informative because it limits the prescriptive-ideology rival. Dialect, learner status, institutional role, and task format remain part of the accountability profile rather than noise to be ignored.

(2) PARADIGM-LEVEL CONTRIBUTION SHOULD SURVIVE TOKEN REDUNDANCY. In gender, agreement, and reference-tracking systems, a manipulation can leave one token’s interpretation unchanged while the paradigm remains informative across its opportunities. Comprehension probes

should find token-level null effects alongside a positive paradigm-level contribution and concentrated correction. A closed, dense contrast with a near-zero paradigm-level contribution that produces the same value-confusion and repair profile as an operator would falsify the proposed boundary. Historical recruitment can't be invoked after that result to preserve membership.

(3) OPERATOR PROFILES SHOULD CROSS EXPRESSIVE SUBSTANCE. In languages where tone, intonation, or nonmanual marking realizes an operator value, wrong values should pattern with segmental operator errors more closely than with matched accent or stance variation (Hyman, 2011; Ladd, 2008). The comparison has to match opportunity and frequency. Tsiwah et al. (2021) report a P600-like response to one temporal-agreement violation in Akan, where time reference is expressed through grammatical tone; the prediction concerns the broader matched response profile, not a unique ERP component.

Operationally, compare tonal tense mismatches, segmental tense or agreement mismatches, and sociophonetic tone shifts. Wrong values may prompt reanalysis of material in scope; value-intact exponent errors should concentrate correction on the form. This error-locus split is more specific than the familiar contrast between morphosyntactic and conceptual anomaly (Friederici, 2011; Kutas & Hillyard, 1980; Osterhout & Holcomb, 1992).

Two further expectations are corollaries rather than discriminating tests. First, resistance to satiation should increase with independently measured evidence concentration and effective preemption, for operator and non-operator constructions alike (Bybee, 2006, 2010; Reynolds, 2026a; Snyder, 2000; Sprouse, 2009). Left-branch extraction belongs in this comparison only if niche norming confirms it as a preempted gap. Second, accent and register should show systematic indexical fields (Agha, 2007; Eckert, 2008); they qualify as operators only if they also form closed paradigms with public-update roles.

The disconfirmation condition compares contrasts after matching closure, opportunity, competitor strength, surprisal, prosody, and task. Contrasts with and without a measured public-update role should differ in comprehension or repair profile. If they don't, public-update role adds no explanatory value beyond constructional licensing and entrenchment.

These predictions don't require new simulation or proof. They require independent measurement of paradigm closure, opportunity count, public-update contribution, and error locus.

11 CONCLUSION

Clausal architecture often enters grammaticality judgments in much the same way as tense or number marking, while accent and much lexical choice are treated differently. Operator structure explains part of that pattern. Constructional licensing, operator membership, value selection, and exponent licensing remain separable dimensions.

Clausal architecture belongs to the operator stratum where a closed paradigm configures clause type, commitment, role allocation, scope, or reference tracking. Tense and number qualify where their paradigms do that work; tone, gesture, particles, word order, and inflection can realize the same values. Complementation can instead be a community-specific constructional convention, as with *depend on*, without thereby becoming an operator contrast.

The public-update condition applies to the paradigm, not every token. A locally redundant concord marker can belong to a reference-tracking system; **goed* and **le hiver* can preserve the intended value while selecting an excluded exponent. Opportunity density sharpens these licensing patterns

but doesn't create operator membership, and population persistence requires more than speaker-level updating.

The asterisk is evidence, not a definition. The projective claim is that independently identified operator paradigms support further expectations about comprehension, repair, and cross-substance response profiles within specified communities and activities. The account proposes no corrective-control mechanism (Reynolds, 2026b; Weinberger, 2026). Its diachronic suggestion – that public-update work favours recruitment into closed paradigms – remains a testable support hypothesis, not a synchronic membership condition.

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